FOR WOMEN WHO ARE NOT HUNGRY

The 20-Gram Rule

Seven days of tiny, no-cook meals for women who are barely hungry and do not want to lose muscle. The grams are already added up.

The Kira Method · 7 daily menus · Protein cheat sheet · Swaps · Shopping list · Tracker

READ THIS FIRST

Who this plan is for

This plan is for women whose appetite is low, whether from a GLP-1 medicine, stress, illness recovery, a busy life, or simply getting older, and who want to keep protein up so their muscles are not what they lose.

This is education, not medical advice. Protein needs differ. If you have kidney disease, liver disease, diabetes, an eating disorder, or you are pregnant or breastfeeding, talk to your doctor or a registered dietitian before you change your protein intake. If you have lost weight without trying, or you cannot eat enough for days, tell your doctor.

Why protein, when you eat so little?

When you eat less, your body can use muscle for fuel. Protein at each meal gives your muscles a reason to stay. The standard U.S. recommendation is 0.8 grams per kilogram of body weight a day, which is the minimum to avoid deficiency. For people on GLP-1 medicines, expert groups commonly suggest more, often around 1.2 to 1.6 grams per kilogram a day, together with strength training. Your own number is a question for your doctor or dietitian. If you are on a GLP-1 medicine, the guide "The Muscle Tax" has a table to calculate it.

The 20-Gram Rule

Every time you sit down to eat, aim for about 20 grams of protein, even if the meal is tiny. When your appetite is small, that means two or three small foods together, not a big plate. Four 20-gram stops a day get you into the range most people are aiming for, without forcing yourself to finish big meals.

The 5 rules

1. **Protein first.** Eat the protein part before anything else.
2. **Four stops, about 20 grams each.** Breakfast, lunch, afternoon, dinner. Add a sip of milk or a shake if you still have room.
3. **Cold and bland is fine.** Cold food has less smell and often feels better when you are nauseous.
4. **Eat by the clock.** Set reminders, do not wait for hunger.
5. **Sip, do not gulp.** Drink protein over 20–30 minutes, and drink water between meals, not in large amounts with them.

THE PLAN

7 days of 20-gram stops

Each stop is built to give about 20 grams. Each day adds up to the protein shown. Grams are approximate and based on typical portions, so read your labels. Swap any meal with another of similar protein (see the swaps page).

Day 1 · about 88 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	Greek yogurt, plain nonfat, 3/4 cup + almonds, 1/4 cup — yogurt with almonds and berries	~23 g
Lunch	canned tuna, 3 oz — on toast or greens	~20 g
Afternoon	hard-boiled egg + hard-boiled egg + string cheese, 1 stick — two hard-boiled eggs and a cheese stick	~19 g
Dinner	cooked chicken breast, 3 oz — with vegetables	~26 g

Day 2 · about 83 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	2 scrambled eggs + string cheese, 1 stick — scrambled eggs and a cheese stick	~19 g
Lunch	lentil soup or cooked lentils, 1 cup + hummus, 1/4 cup — lentil soup with hummus and veggies	~23 g
Afternoon	cottage cheese, 1/2 cup + almonds, 1/4 cup — cottage cheese with fruit and almonds	~20 g
Dinner	cooked salmon, 3 oz — with greens	~21 g

Day 3 · about 87 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	protein shake, 1 scoop powder in water — sip slowly over 20 minutes	~22 g
Lunch	deli turkey, 2 oz + hummus, 1/4 cup + cheddar cheese, 1 oz — turkey, hummus and cheese in a wrap	~22 g
Afternoon	Greek yogurt, plain nonfat, 3/4 cup + almonds, 1/4 cup — yogurt with almonds	~23 g
Dinner	cooked shrimp, 3 oz — with rice or vegetables	~20 g

Day 4 · about 90 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	Greek yogurt, plain nonfat, 3/4 cup + peanut butter, 2 tbsp — yogurt with peanut butter and oats	~23 g
Lunch	canned tuna, 3 oz — tuna salad	~20 g
Afternoon	kefir, 1 cup + hard-boiled egg + hard-boiled egg — kefir and two hard-boiled eggs	~21 g
Dinner	firm tofu, 1/2 cup + shelled edamame, 1/2 cup + peanut butter, 2 tbsp — tofu and edamame stir-fry with peanut sauce	~26 g

Day 5 · about 92 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	2 scrambled eggs + string cheese, 1 stick — scrambled eggs with spinach and a cheese stick	~19 g
Lunch	black beans, 1/2 cup + cheddar cheese, 1 oz + deli turkey, 2 oz — bean, cheese and turkey bowl	~25 g
Afternoon	protein shake, 1 scoop powder in water — sip slowly	~22 g
Dinner	cooked chicken breast, 3 oz — chicken soup or roast	~26 g

Day 6 · about 86 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	cottage cheese, 1/2 cup + almonds, 1/4 cup — cottage cheese with berries and almonds	~20 g
Lunch	cooked salmon, 3 oz — on greens or toast	~21 g
Afternoon	milk, 1 cup + hard-boiled egg + string cheese, 1 stick — a glass of milk, an egg and a cheese stick	~21 g
Dinner	lentil soup or cooked lentils, 1 cup + hard-boiled egg — lentil stew topped with an egg	~24 g

Day 7 · about 90 g protein

Stop	What	Protein
Breakfast	Greek yogurt, plain nonfat, 3/4 cup + almonds, 1/4 cup — yogurt with almonds	~23 g
Lunch	cooked chicken breast, 3 oz — cold chicken with vegetables	~26 g
Afternoon	string cheese, 1 stick + hard-boiled egg + milk, 1 cup — a cheese stick, an egg and a glass of milk	~21 g
Dinner	cooked shrimp, 3 oz — shrimp with vegetables	~20 g

REFERENCE

Protein cheat sheet

Typical values. Brands differ.

Food and portion	Protein
Cooked chicken breast, 3 oz	~26 g
Protein shake, 1 scoop powder in water	~22 g
Cooked salmon, 3 oz	~21 g
Canned tuna, 3 oz	~20 g
Cooked shrimp, 3 oz	~20 g
Lentil soup or cooked lentils, 1 cup	~18 g
Greek yogurt, plain nonfat, 3/4 cup	~16 g
Cottage cheese, 1/2 cup	~13 g
2 scrambled eggs	~12 g
Firm tofu, 1/2 cup	~10 g
Deli turkey, 2 oz	~10 g
Kefir, 1 cup	~9 g
Shelled edamame, 1/2 cup	~9 g
Milk, 1 cup	~8 g
Black beans, 1/2 cup	~8 g
String cheese, 1 stick	~7 g
Almonds, 1/4 cup	~7 g
Peanut butter, 2 tbsp	~7 g
Cheddar cheese, 1 oz	~7 g
Hard-boiled egg	~6 g
Hummus, 1/4 cup	~5 g

MAKE IT WORK

Swaps and fixes

If...	Try
Dairy upsets you	Lactose-free milk or yogurt, soy milk, tofu, canned fish, eggs, lentils, and lactase tablets if your doctor agrees.
You are vegetarian	Eggs, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, tofu, edamame, lentils, beans, nuts, soy milk, and a plant protein powder.
You are on a budget	Eggs, canned tuna, dried lentils and beans, plain yogurt in the big tub, store-brand cottage cheese and milk.
You cannot chew well	Yogurt, cottage cheese, scrambled eggs, soft tofu, smooth soups with lentils, protein shakes.
Meat tastes odd	Cold chicken or fish, eggs, yogurt, tofu. Marinate with lemon or herbs. Plastic utensils can help with metallic tastes.
You feel nauseous	Smaller bites, cold foods, sip slowly, avoid greasy and very sweet foods, stay upright after meals.
You forget to eat	Phone alarms. Pre-pack mini-meals in the front of the fridge.
Shakes taste too sweet	Unflavored or lightly sweetened powder, serve very cold, mix with milk or kefir.

> If you cannot keep food or fluids down for more than a day, are losing weight quickly, or feel dizzy and weak, call your doctor.

Sunday 30-minute prep

☐ Hard-boil 6 to 8 eggs.

☐ Portion yogurt or cottage cheese into small cups.

☐ Cook or buy a rotisserie chicken, and pull it into 3 oz portions.

☐ Portion almonds, cheese and berries into small bags.

☐ Cook a pot of lentils or soup, and portion it.

SHOPPING AND TRACKING

Week shopping list

- ☐ Plain Greek yogurt (large tub)
- ☐ Cottage cheese
- ☐ Eggs (1 dozen)
- ☐ String cheese
- ☐ Cheddar cheese
- ☐ Milk or kefir
- ☐ Canned tuna
- ☐ Salmon fillets or canned salmon
- ☐ Rotisserie chicken or chicken breasts
- ☐ Shrimp (frozen)
- ☐ Deli turkey
- ☐ Lentils (dry or canned) or lentil soup
- ☐ Black beans (canned)
- ☐ Firm tofu
- ☐ Shelled edamame (frozen)
- ☐ Hummus
- ☐ Almonds
- ☐ Peanut butter
- ☐ Protein powder (optional)
- ☐ Berries, apples, vegetables
- ☐ Oats, toast, wraps

7-day tracker

Day	Protein (g)	Meals eaten	Water	Appetite 0–5	Notes
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					

Questions for your doctor or dietitian

- ☐ How much protein is right for me?
- ☐ Do I need any vitamin or mineral checks while my appetite is low?
- ☐ Is a protein shake or supplement right for me, and which kind?
- ☐ How do I know if I am eating too little?

SOURCES

Where this comes from

Written October 2026. Check with your own care team.

- Nutritional priorities to support GLP-1 therapy for obesity: joint advisory of the American College of Lifestyle Medicine, American Society for Nutrition, Obesity Medicine Association and The Obesity Society (2025): adequate protein with strength training to preserve lean mass.
- U.S. Dietary Guidelines: Recommended Dietary Allowance for protein 0.8 g per kg of body weight a day for adults.
- Food protein values: typical values from the USDA FoodData Central. Brands and portions vary, so always read labels.
- ACLM patient handout on GLP-1 side effects (2026): smaller meals, cold or bland foods and fluids for nausea.

> This plan is educational. It is not medical advice, diagnosis or treatment. Talk to your doctor or a registered dietitian before you change your diet, especially with a medical condition. Individual results vary and no specific outcome is promised.

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